Throughout the first millennium, the erotic and the celibate had been two conflicting yet coexisting ideals in Indian religiosity. In Chandela times, Tantra upheld the erotic while coexisting with the celibate ideals of devotional and Brahminical Hinduism. After Adi Shankara (eighth century), Hinduism's shift towards more sexually puritanical and patriarchal modes only increased—largely due to internal fault lines and religious developments *within* Hinduism.

Khajuraho was very much a centre of these developments, evident in the Chandela court play, *Prabodhachandrodaya* ('moon rise of true knowledge'), a philosophical allegory in six acts written by Krishna Mishra. Staged in 1065 CE, the play, set in Varanasi, defends the Advaita doctrine and Vishnu Bhakti via a contest between the noble king Viveka ('Discrimination') and the wicked king Mahamoha ('Delusion'). In the play, writes Desai, 'the forces of orthodox religion based on Vedic order unite to re-establish the ancient order against those non-Vedic heretical forces which had earlier gained ascendancy'. It rails against the extreme Kapalika Tantrics, Jain and Buddhist mendicants, materialist–*nastika* Carvakas and other anti-Vedic sects. Desai cites evidence to show that this basic conflict played out in art and literature in many parts of India across multiple centuries from Gupta to Chandela times.[51]

In parallel, Bhakti advanced among the masses at the expense of the Tantric substrate. Bhakti espoused devotion and surrender of the self to a personal god, *contempt for worldly pleasures*, and distrust in priestly rituals. It partly shared with the Tantric substrate its anti-caste, anti-ritual and female-friendly impulses—evident later in activist saints like Namdev, Janabai, Ravidas, Kabir and Tukaram, but who also differed greatly from the pleasure-affirming Tantric acharyas of the Chandela times. Bhakti's path to liberation was paved with chaste devotion, not yogic sex. In time, Bhakti helped decimate the sex-positive culture of Tantra.

In other words, a profound shift was occurring in the Indian religious market that revived Brahminism and fuelled the Bhakti movement, both of which are sexually puritanical strains of faith. This churn and puritanical shift in Hinduism began long before the coming of Islam which, arguably, only hastened the trend. Indeed, in terms of sexual puritanism, orthodox